

English

Year 7

Cambridge Lower Secondary

Student Manual



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INTRODUCTION

How this book works

You become a better writer by reading like a writer, and a better reader by writing like a reader. Every unit in this book pairs an original text with the craft that makes it work, then asks you to use that craft yourself.

Original texts, real craft

Every story and poem here was written for this book. You are always reading something new, and always learning a technique writers really use.

Read closely, then write

Each session moves the same way: read, notice how it was made, then make something of your own using the same tools.

Your voice matters

You will read aloud, perform, argue a case and give feedback. Speaking is not an extra here. It is part of how you learn to write.

Nothing is decoration

Every panel on the page has a job. Once you know what each one is for, you can find your way through any unit on your own.

What you will do in Unit 1

Read an adventure

You will follow an original story from a still, strange morning in a Cascais boatyard to its most dangerous hour.

Write your own

You will finish the unit by planning, drafting and editing the opening of an adventure that is entirely yours.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

Finding your way around a page

Each session follows the same rhythm, so you always know where you are.



In this session, you will

The promises the session makes to you. Read it first, and check it at the end.



Getting started

A short warm-up that wakes up what you already know before you read.



Extract

An original text to read closely: a story, a poem or an article.



Key words

The vocabulary of the session, explained in plain language.



Reading tip

A strategy that makes you a sharper, more suspicious reader.



Speaking tip

Advice for reading aloud, performing and being heard.



Language focus

A close look at how a grammatical choice creates an effect.



Peer assessment

How to read a partner's work usefully, and how to use what they tell you.



Summary checklist

"I can" statements so you can check your own progress honestly.



Think like a writer

An invitation to experiment, take a risk and try a technique out.

A note for teachers and parents

Texts are original

Every extract is written for this book, so nothing is behind a copyright wall and every text can be freely copied, read aloud and annotated in class.

Speaking is assessed

Discussion, performance and peer feedback appear in every session and are part of the learning, not an optional extra.

BEFORE WE GET STARTED

What you need, and what you already have

You need only three things for this unit: this book, a notebook, and something to write with. Everything else is already inside you: an ear for a good story, and a lifetime of them to draw on.

Your reader's toolkit

- A willingness to read the same text twice, slowly the second time.
- A dictionary habit: when a word stops you, look it up, then use it.
- A voice: you will be asked to read aloud, so be ready to be heard.

A QUICK SELF-CHECK

Think of a story you love, from a book, a film or a game. Answer these four questions about it.

1. Who is the main character, and what do they want?
2. Where and when is it set, and how do you know?
3. What goes wrong, or what danger appears?
4. How does it end, and how does that make you feel?

Those four questions are the skeleton of almost every adventure ever told.

In this unit you will learn to see that skeleton beneath any story, and then to build a story of your own upon it.

One last thing

Adventure stories are about people who go somewhere they were told not to go. Reading is the safest way of doing exactly that. Turn the page.

UNIT 1

1

Adventure

Reading like a writer, writing like a reader

© IN THIS UNIT, YOU WILL

- ✓ Explore how genre and setting shape an adventure story.
- ✓ Read an original adventure extract closely and critically.
- ✓ Plan and write a monologue in a character's voice.
- ✓ Discover how poets use alliteration and sibilance.
- ✓ Analyse how language choices create suspense.
- ✓ Write and edit the suspenseful opening of your own story.

◆ GETTING STARTED

Adventure stories are a **genre**. That means they share recognisable features. In pairs, discuss:

- the kinds of characters you meet in adventure stories
- the kinds of settings where adventures happen
- what usually goes wrong, and what danger appears
- how adventure stories usually end

Compare your ideas with another partner. Apart from the hero, what other sorts of people tend to appear in adventure stories?

■ KEY WORDS

- **genre**: a particular type of text, such as adventure, comedy or fantasy.
- **setting**: the place and time in which a story happens.

The start of an adventure

The extract

Read this opening of an original adventure story, written for this book. It is about a girl called Beatriz, whose adventure begins on the morning she finds something impossible in her grandfather's boatyard.



The setting. A boatyard at Cascais, early morning: wooden hulls on trestles, coiled rope, and a brass compass on the bench.

“ EXTRACT 1 • 'THE TIDE THAT WAITED' ”

The morning the tide refused to turn, Beatriz was the only one who noticed. She had grown up in the boatyard at Cascais, and she knew the harbour the way other children knew their own bedrooms: every rope, every rusted cleat, every gull that thought it owned the place. The tide came in, the tide went out. That was the rule. That morning, it simply stopped, as if the whole Atlantic were holding its breath.

Her grandfather was down by the water, standing very still. 'Avô?' she called. He did not turn. In his hands he held the old brass compass that had belonged to his grandfather, and its needle was spinning, slowly, the wrong way. 'Beatriz,' he said at last, in the quiet voice he used for storms and funerals. 'Go inside. Lock the door.' But she did not go inside, because that was the moment she saw the light under the water, green and patient, watching.

READING TIP

When you come across a word you do not know, use the sentences around it to work out its meaning. In the first paragraph, you can work out what "holding its breath" suggests about the sea by thinking about how still and silent the harbour has become.

- 1 Practise working out meanings from **context**. These words come from the extract. What do you think each means? A. cleat B. compass C. patient
- 2 What is the setting of this story? Find two details that tell you.
- 3 Beatriz's grandfather says "in the quiet voice he used for storms and funerals". What does this tell you about what is coming?

■ KEY WORDS

- **context**: the words and situation around something, which help you understand it.

The quest

From reading to writing

Beatriz's adventure is a **quest**: a journey with a goal, full of obstacles. In the next part of the story she leaves the safety of the boatyard to discover why the tide has stopped, and what the green light wants. A quest story is built from a chain of events, each one harder than the last.

- 1 Plan a monologue called 'The Light under the Water', told from Beatriz's point of view, for the moment she first rows out towards the green light.
 - a. On your own, make brief notes on:
 - what Beatriz can see, hear and feel as she rows out
 - what she is afraid of, and what she hopes to find
 - a. Think about the **narrative structure** of your monologue. List the events in the order you will tell them.
- 2 Now write your monologue. You are writing from Beatriz's point of view, so you must capture her **voice**. She is young, but she is brave and curious; she has also been warned to stay away, so she may be cautious and a little frightened. Choose words that convey all of this.

⇌ PEER ASSESSMENT

In groups, take turns reading your monologue aloud.

- Which parts of each monologue were the most interesting to listen to, and why?
- Did the writer capture Beatriz's voice? Give reasons for your assessment.

🗣️ SPEAKING TIP

Before you read your monologue aloud, plan how you will speak. Which words will you emphasise? Where will you pause? How can you make the moment the light appears sound thrilling?

■ KEY WORDS

- **voice:** the way a particular character speaks or thinks in fiction, or a writer's tone in non-fiction.
- **narrative structure:** the order in which the events of a story are told.

☑ SUMMARY CHECKLIST

- ✓ I can predict how a story might develop.
- ✓ I can identify the features of a monologue.
- ✓ I can write and perform a monologue in a character's voice.

Building suspense

How writers hold a reader

Suspense is the feeling of anxious excitement that makes you keep reading. Writers create it on purpose. They withhold information, slow down at the dangerous moment, and make the familiar feel suddenly strange.

- 1 Look again at the extract in Session 1.1. Find one example of each technique:
 - a. something the writer does not explain, so you have to read on
 - b. a place where the writing slows down at a tense moment
 - c. an ordinary, familiar thing that becomes unsettling

∴ THINK LIKE A WRITER

Take the sentence "She opened the door." Rewrite it three different ways to build suspense, using a different technique each time: withhold something, slow the moment down, or make the ordinary strange. Which of your three versions is most effective, and why?

A hard journey

The poem

Adventures are not only told in prose. Read this original poem about a traveller crossing a difficult country.

“ EXTRACT 2 • ‘THE LONG ROAD OVER SERRA’

The road was stone, the sky was grey,
I walked where wind and wild goats stray.

My boots were worn, my pack was sore,
The summit seemed a day or more.

The sleet came soft, then sharp, then slow,
It whispered through the pass below.

But still I climbed, and still I sang,
Until the church-bell coldly rang.

And there below, the village lay,
Its lamps aglow at close of day.

I stumbled down, my journey done,
The road behind, the rest begun.

- 1 Copy and complete this table to list the events of each **stanza**. The first has been done as an example.

STANZA	WHAT HAPPENS
1	The narrator describes the hard, stony road and grey sky.
2	
3	
4	
5	
6	

LANGUAGE FOCUS

Poets use sound effects deliberately. **Alliteration** is the repetition of a consonant sound at the start of nearby words, as in "stone" and "sky". It can make a line feel hard, fast or forceful. **Sibilance** is the repetition of soft 's' and 'sh' sounds, as in "sleet came soft, then sharp, then slow". It can suggest whispering, wind or water. Read the poem aloud and listen for both.

- 1 Read the poem again. Identify one example of alliteration and one of sibilance, and describe the effect each creates.
- 2 In stanza 4, the narrator keeps climbing and singing despite the sleet. What does this tell you about the narrator?

■ KEY WORDS

- **stanza:** a group of lines in a poem, sometimes called a verse.
- **alliteration:** the repetition of the same consonant sound at the start of nearby words.
- **sibilance:** the repetition of soft 's' and 'sh' sounds for emphasis.

The writer's toolkit

Language and effect

Every choice a writer makes has an effect. A short sentence can land like a blow. A list can build a rhythm. An unexpected word can startle a reader awake.

- 1 Look at this sentence from the poem: "I stumbled down, my journey done."
 - a. Why do you think the poet chose "stumbled" rather than "walked"?
 - b. What effect does the short phrase "my journey done" create at the end of a line?
- 2 Choose one line from either extract that you think is especially effective. Write a sentence explaining the choice the writer made and its effect.

✦ DID YOU KNOW?

The word "adventure" comes from the Latin *adventurus*, "about to happen". Every adventure story is, at its heart, about something that is just about to happen, which is exactly the feeling of suspense you have been studying.

Writing your own adventure

Planning, drafting, editing

Now it is your turn. You are going to write the suspenseful opening of an adventure story of your own invention.

- 1 Plan your opening by making notes on these questions:
 - Who is your main character, and what do they want?
 - Where and when is your story set?
 - What impossible or dangerous thing appears at the start?
 - What will you withhold from the reader to create suspense?
- 2 Write the first two or three paragraphs of your story. Aim to make your reader desperate to know what happens next.
- 3 Edit your draft. Read it aloud. Cut any word that is not doing work, and strengthen your single most suspenseful sentence.

⇌ PEER ASSESSMENT

Swap openings with a partner. Read your partner's opening and tell them: the moment you most wanted to read on, and one place where they could build even more suspense. Then revise your own opening using their feedback.

☑ SUMMARY CHECKLIST

- ✓ I can comment on the features of adventure and suspense stories.
- ✓ I can describe the effects of language and grammatical choices.
- ✓ I can plan, write and edit a suspenseful story opening.

The adventure anthology

★ FINAL PROJECT

The adventure anthology

Your class is going to publish an anthology of original adventure openings. Yours will be one of them. Polish the opening you drafted in Session 1.6 into a finished piece of between 300 and 400 words, ready for publication.

What to hand in

- Your polished opening of 300 to 400 words, with a title.
- A short writer's commentary explaining two techniques you used and why.
- A one-line "hook" for the back of the anthology, to make a reader pick your story.

How it will be judged

CRITERION	WEIGHT
Suspense and reader engagement	40%
Control of language and voice	30%
Quality of editing and polish	20%
The writer's commentary	10%

Before you hand it in

Opening line

Does your first sentence make a reader need the second one?

Setting

Can a reader see and hear where they are within the first paragraph?

Withholding

Have you kept one thing back deliberately, so the reader has to keep going?

Tense

Is your tense consistent, and does any shift happen on purpose?

Read aloud

Have you read it out loud and cut the words you stumbled over?

Title

Does your title promise something without giving it away?

UNIT 1 • CHECK YOUR PROGRESS

- 1 What is a genre? Name two features of the adventure genre.
- 2 What is the difference between a story's setting and its narrative structure?
- 3 What is a monologue, and what does it mean to capture a character's voice?
- 4 Define alliteration and sibilance, and give an example of each.
- 5 Name two techniques a writer can use to build suspense.
- 6 Why might a writer choose a short sentence at a tense moment?
- 7 What does it mean to "read like a writer"?
- 8 In the poem 'The Long Road over Serra', what journey does the narrator make, and how do they feel when it ends?
- 9 Write one suspenseful sentence about a character opening a door.

UNIT 1 • EVALUATION

Be honest. Colour the circle that matches how you feel about each outcome: green means confident, amber means nearly there, red means needs more work.

I CAN ...	GREEN	AMBER	RED
identify the features of an adventure story	☐	☐	☐
read an extract closely and work out meanings from context	☐	☐	☐
write and perform a monologue in a character's voice	☐	☐	☐
identify alliteration and sibilance and describe their effects	☐	☐	☐
analyse how language choices create suspense	☐	☐	☐
write and edit a suspenseful opening	☐	☐	☐

UNIT 1 • WHAT CAN YOU DO?

✓ WHAT CAN YOU DO?

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Identify the genre and setting of a story. | ☐ Identify alliteration and sibilance in a poem. |
| ☐ Work out word meanings from context. | ☐ Analyse how writers build suspense. |
| ☐ Write a monologue in a character's voice. | ☐ Plan, draft and edit a suspenseful opening. |

■ UNIT 1 ROUND-UP

genre · setting · context · voice · narrative structure · stanza · alliteration · sibilance · suspense

GLOSSARY

Unit 1

alliteration: the repetition of the same consonant sound at the start of nearby words, used to create a particular effect.

context: the words and situation around something, which help you understand it.

genre: a particular type of text, such as adventure, comedy or fantasy.

narrative structure: the order in which the events of a story are told.

setting: the place and time in which a story happens.

sibilance: the repetition of soft 's' and 'sh' sounds for emphasis.

stanza: a group of lines in a poem, sometimes called a verse.

suspense: the feeling of anxious excitement that keeps a reader reading.

voice: the way a particular character speaks or thinks in fiction, or a writer's tone in non-fiction.

SOURCES & REFERENCES

Where everything came from

The texts in this unit are original works written for this book. The factual and etymological notes can be checked [here](#). Links were live as of July 2026.

S UNIT 1 • ADVENTURE

- 1 **Cascais.** The fishing town and boatyard used as the setting for the original story 'The Tide that Waited'. A real coastal town in Portugal.
<<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cascais>>
- 2 **The etymology of "adventure".** From the Latin *adventurus*, "about to happen", cited in the "Did you know?" panel of Session 1.5.
<<https://www.etymonline.com/word/adventure>>
- 3 **'The Tide that Waited' and 'The Long Road over Serra'.** Original story and poem written for this book. © Prime School 2026.

Read like a writer. Write like a reader.

This Year 7 Student Book takes you inside the craft of the written word. You will travel with an original adventure story, hear how a poet makes a journey out of sound, and learn the techniques that make readers keep turning pages. Then you will use every one of them to write an adventure of your own.

Written for Prime School pupils, in clear British English, with original stories and poems set in Portugal.

ADVENTURE

POETRY

SUSPENSE

VOICE

CRAFT